

# HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN PALAU

## *Complete Community Opposition How-To*

*This guide is built around how Palauans turned good science and their own tradition into lasting protection — a community that took reef science to its own leaders and won a ban, then drew on the traditional moratorium called "bul" to protect land, watersheds, and reefs — and it names the tools you'll meet (the land-and-sea science, the "bul" moratorium, the community alliance, the state and traditional leaders) in plain words.*

## INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

When scientists demonstrated that clearing the land — and especially the **mangroves** along the shore — was sending sediment onto the **reefs** and harming the fish that feed Palauan families, the people of one state did something practical and effective: they took that evidence to their own **state government and traditional leaders** and lobbied until the **clearing of mangroves was banned**. And that was not a lone act. Across the largest island, community after community, working together through an **alliance**, drew on Palau's own tradition of the temporary moratorium the islands call "**bul**," and established their own **protected areas** on the land — turning scientific understanding and cultural practice into lasting protection for the forests, the watersheds, and the reefs below them. The destructive clearing was stopped where the community made its case; the protected areas hold.

The Palauan communities who won a mangrove-clearing ban drew on tools rooted in the islands' own tradition. The distinctive one is **clear science linking land to sea** — the sediment, the reefs, the fish — which gives a community something a leader can act on, as it won the ban. The **traditional "bul" moratorium** — Palau's own custom of temporarily closing an area to let it recover — is a living, culturally-rooted tool for protection. A **community alliance**, communities acting together, multiplies the power, as it did across the largest island. The **state government and traditional leaders**, closest to home, are the people with the power to respond; protest, petition, and lobbying are lawful and safe. And Palau's **strong conservation tradition and national leadership** stand behind it. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Palau's great national acts — the vast **National Marine Sanctuary**, the world-first **shark sanctuary** — were led by national leaders, and a community's power is strongest at the **state and traditional level**, on the land and reefs closest to home. The science must be **clear and credible** to persuade. And the **pressure for development** on small, beautiful islands is real. So aim for what these levers can deliver by arming the community with science and taking it to the leaders closest to home.

## The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A destructive practice on small islands looks hard to stop, but it depends on being tolerated by the leaders and communities closest to it — and a community armed with clear science and a living tradition is a chain's strongest link. A Palauan fight turns on the **land-and-sea science**; on the **"bul" moratorium**; on the **community alliance**; on the **state and traditional leaders**; and on **community-run protected areas**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and clear science, taken to the leaders closest to home, is the one that won the mangrove ban. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

## Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this, work out your real situation:

- **If you can show clear science linking a project to reef and fish harm, take it to your leaders** — that link won the mangrove ban.
- **If a living tradition offers a tool, use it** — the "bul" moratorium turned understanding into lasting protection.
- **If communities can act together, that multiplies the power** — an alliance protected land across the largest island.
- **But know that a community's power is strongest close to home** — the great national sanctuaries were national-led; your strength is at the state and traditional level.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **arm the community with clear, credible science that links a project to the harm it does the reefs and fish**, and **take it to the leaders closest to home — state and traditional — and turn it into lasting protection through "bul" and community protected areas**.

## HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a practice is stopped, and where a community's power lies.

### Who Actually Decides

Palau has a **national government** and **state governments**, and, woven through both, **traditional leaders** whose authority is real. Great national acts — the **National Marine Sanctuary**, the **shark sanctuary** — come from national leadership. But a community's power is strongest at the **state and traditional level**, on the land and reefs closest to home, where **science** can persuade leaders to ban a practice, where the traditional **"bul"** can close an area, and where a **community alliance** can establish protected areas. Know which of these you can reach — the leaders closest to home are usually the ones who can act.

### How a Practice Is Stopped — and Where You Jump In

**The harm, shown clearly.** A practice does harm that science can link to the reefs and fish. *Your opening — the decisive one:* clear science a leader can act on.

**The leaders closest to home.** *Your opening:* the state government and traditional leaders with the power to ban or protect.

**The tradition.** *Your opening:* the "bul" moratorium, a living tool to close and protect an area.

**The alliance.** *Your opening:* communities acting together to establish protected areas.

### Follow the Science and the Custom

Dig up three things. **The science that links the project to the harm** — the sediment, the reef damage, the lost fish — because clear science is what a leader can act on, as it won the mangrove ban. **Who has the power closest to home** — the state government, the traditional leaders — the people to persuade. **What tradition and community structures you can use** — the "bul" moratorium, the community alliance, the protected areas — the tools that turn understanding into lasting protection.

### Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. **State governments** and **traditional leaders** hold the power closest to home to ban a practice or protect an area. The **"bul"** tradition is a tool the community itself can invoke. A **community alliance** multiplies the effort. **Reef scientists and conservation groups** supply the credible science. And Palau's **national conservation leadership** — the marine and shark sanctuaries — sets a powerful example and stands behind protection.

## QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, on small islands with a strong conservation tradition but real development pressure. What most moves them: the clarity of the science and the reach to the leaders closest to home.

| What you do                            | Roughly works | How long  | Cost | What "works" means                        |
|----------------------------------------|---------------|-----------|------|-------------------------------------------|
| Just gather documents                  | 5–10%         | weeks     | low  | The base for everything else              |
| Show clear land-to-sea science         | 35–60%        | months    | low  | Evidence a leader can act on              |
| Take it to state + traditional leaders | 40–65%        | months    | low  | A practice banned (the mangroves)         |
| Invoke the "bul" moratorium            | 40–65%        | months    | low  | An area closed and protected              |
| Build a community alliance             | 35–60%        | months–yr | low  | Protected areas across communities        |
| Establish community protected areas    | 40–65%        | months–yr | low  | Lasting protection that holds             |
| <b>Everything together</b>             | <b>50–70%</b> | months–yr | low  | A practice stopped, protection that holds |
| Reaching national-scale acts           | harder        | years     | mod  | Those came from national leadership       |

The levers that move the needle most are **clear land-to-sea science** and the **reach to the leaders closest to home**, backed by the **"bul" moratorium** and a **community alliance**. Palau shows the ceiling (a practice banned and lasting protected areas established by communities armed with science and tradition) and the honest floor (the great national acts came from national leadership, and a community's power is strongest close to home). So aim for a practice banned, land and mangroves protected, and watersheds and reefs safeguarded — by arming the community with science and reaching the leaders closest to home.

*On cost: Palau's levers cost mainly credible science and organised community effort, not much money — the science, the lobbying of state and traditional leaders, the "bul," and the community protected areas are within a community's reach. The great strength is a living conservation tradition and leaders close to home who can act; the honest limit is that a community's power is strongest at the state and traditional level, and the science must be clear enough to persuade.*

## STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "development" is weak. Being specific — this practice, this reef harm, this leader — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

**1. What is it, and what harm does it do?** Name the practice or project (land clearing, mangrove cutting, a development), and the harm — and, crucially, **the science that links it to the reefs and fish**, as the sediment link won the mangrove ban.

**2. Can you show the land-to-sea link clearly?** Whether **reef scientists** can show the harm clearly — because clear science is what a leader can act on.

**3. Who has the power closest to home?** The **state government and traditional leaders** with the authority to ban the practice or protect the area.

**4. What tradition and structures can you use?** The **"bul"** moratorium, a **community alliance**, **community protected areas** — the tools that turn understanding into lasting protection.

**5. Who's your community?** The families whose fish and forests and water are at stake — the people the science and the tradition serve.

**What this looks like in real life.** A practice on the land is quietly harming the reefs and the fish. The five questions yield: the practice and its harm; the reef science that links land to sea (the decisive evidence); the state and traditional leaders who can act; the **"bul"** and community protected areas to make protection last; and a community to serve. That's the Palauan pattern — arm the community with clear science, take it to the leaders closest to home, and turn it into lasting protection through tradition.

## STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community a leader can act for and one they can't is proof — the clear science that links a project to reef and fish harm. Build it in three layers.

**Layer one: the land-to-sea science.** Document, with **reef scientists**, the **link between the practice and the harm** — the sediment washing onto the reefs, the smothered corals, the thinned fish — because this clear link is what a leader can act on, as it won the mangrove ban.

**Layer two: the stake for families.** Document what the community **depends on** — the fish, the forests, the watersheds — because the harm to families' food and water is what moves leaders and unites communities.

**Layer three: the tools to make it last.** Identify the **state and traditional leaders** to persuade, and the **"bul"** and **community protected areas** to turn a ban into lasting protection. Walking to the leaders closest to home with clear science and a plan for lasting protection is what worked across Palau.

## WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The land-to-sea science** — the sediment, the reef harm, the lost fish, shown clearly.
- **The stake** — the fish, forests, and watersheds families depend on.
- **The leaders** — the state government and traditional leaders who can act.
- **The tradition** — the **"bul"** moratorium and how to invoke it.
- **The structures** — the community alliance and protected areas to make protection last.

## STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community armed with science and rooted in tradition gives you the power that won the mangrove ban and built protected areas across an island. Build in four moves.

**Root it in the fish, the forests, and the families.** Palauans acted because the harm reached their food and their reefs. Root the effort in what the community depends on — the fish, the watersheds, the reefs — and what the harm means for families.

**Bring in the reef scientists.** The decisive step: clear science linking the practice to the reef and fish harm, which gives a leader something to act on. Bring in reef scientists and conservation groups to make the link credible and clear.

**Take it to the leaders closest to home.** Lobby the **state government and traditional leaders** with the science — the people closest to home with the power to ban the practice or protect the area, as the mangrove ban was won.

**Use the tradition and build an alliance.** Invoke the "**bul**" moratorium to close and protect an area, build a **community alliance** so communities act together, and establish **community protected areas** to make the protection last — as across the largest island.

## STEP 4: SCIENCE, LEADERS & THE "BUL"

Palau's levers combine clear science, the leaders closest to home, and a living tradition.

### The Land-to-Sea Science — the Decisive Lever

The Palauan lever: arm the community with **clear science** that links a practice to the harm it does the **reefs and the fish** people depend on — because this clear link is what a leader can act on, as the sediment science won the mangrove ban. Make the science clear and credible, with reef scientists.

### The Leaders Closest to Home

Take the science to the **state government and traditional leaders** — the people closest to home with the power to respond. A community's power is strongest here, at the state and traditional level, on the land and reefs closest to it.

### The "Bul" Moratorium and Community Protected Areas

Turn understanding into lasting protection through Palau's own tradition: the "**bul**" moratorium, which temporarily closes an area to let it recover, and **community-run protected areas**, built together through a **community alliance** — as across the largest island, where scientific understanding and cultural practice became lasting protection.

### The Honest Limits

Straight talk: a community's power is strongest close to home — the great national acts, the marine and shark sanctuaries, came from national leadership; the science must be clear and credible to persuade a leader; and development pressure on small, beautiful islands is real. So use the levers — the science, the leaders closest to home, the "bul," the community protected areas — and count a practice banned, land and mangroves protected, and watersheds and reefs safeguarded as wins.

## TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

**Harm becomes a link a leader can act on.** Not "we don't like this" but "*the sediment from this clearing is smothering our reefs and thinning the fish our families eat,*" as the science that won the mangrove ban.

**A tradition becomes a tool.** "*We can place a 'bul' on this area, as our custom allows, and let it recover.*"

**A reef becomes a family's food.** "*These are the reefs and fish our families rely on — protecting them protects us.*"

**Communities together become a movement.** "*Community after community can protect its own land and reefs, together,*" as across the island.

Match it to the venue: the science to the state and traditional leaders; the "bul" to the community and its custom; the family stake to the public; the protected areas to the alliance.

## STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Palau, the "media" front is often close and personal — persuading state and traditional leaders and the community itself — because a community's power is strongest close to home, and clear science and shared tradition are what persuade.

**Lead with the reefs, the fish, and the families, not abstraction.** Not "sedimentation impacts benthic habitat" but "the mud from this clearing is smothering our reefs and taking food from our families' tables." Use your strongest material: the clear science, the reefs and fish, and what they mean to families.

**Work the leaders and the community.** State and traditional leaders can act; the community sustains the protection. Make it easy: clear, credible science, and a plan rooted in tradition — the "bul," the community protected areas.

**Two hard rules.** Accuracy above all — the science must be clear and credible to persuade a leader. And honor the tradition: root the protection in Palau's own custom, which gives it lasting strength.

## EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

**8A — To state and traditional leaders (with the science).**

*Subject: The science on [practice] and our reefs.*

"We bring you clear evidence that [practice] is [sending sediment onto our reefs / harming our fish]: [specifics]. We ask you to [ban it / protect the area], as the mangrove clearing was banned. [Attach the science.]"

**8B — Proposing a "bul" moratorium.**

*Subject: A "bul" for [area].*

"We ask that a 'bul' be placed on [area] to let it recover, as our tradition allows: [specifics and reasons]. [Contact.]"

**8C — To reef scientists / conservation groups.**

*Subject: Help us show the harm from [practice].*

"We seek your help to show clearly the link between [practice] and the harm to our reefs and fish: [specifics]. [Contact.]"

**8D — Building a community alliance.**

*Subject: Let's protect our land and reefs together.*

"We, [community], propose an alliance to establish protected areas across our communities, as across the largest island: [specifics]. [Contact.]"

**8E — Establishing a community protected area.**

*Subject: A protected area for [place].*

"We propose to establish a community protected area at [place], to safeguard [forests/watersheds/reefs]: [specifics and plan]. [Contact.]"

**8F — To the state government.**

*Subject: Protecting our reefs and fish from [practice].*

"We are the community of [place], asking you to act on clear science and [ban the practice / protect the area]: [specifics]. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

**8G — Letter to the public / press.**

*Subject: The mud smothering our reefs — and how we can stop it.*

"[Practice] is harming the reefs and fish our families depend on. Clear science shows it, and our tradition offers a way to protect them. [Contact.]"

**8H — Rallying the community.**

*Subject: Our reefs, our fish, our tradition.*

"[Practice] threatens our reefs and fish. Palauans won a ban with science and protected their land with 'bul.' Let's do the same. [Contact.]"

## **IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION**

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Get clear science linking the practice to reef and fish harm (8C).**
2. **Take it to the state and traditional leaders closest to home (8A).**
3. **Ask them to ban the practice or protect the area (8F).**
4. **Propose a "bul" moratorium to let the area recover (8B).**
5. **Build a community alliance and protected areas to make it last (8D/8E).**
6. **Rally the community and public around the reefs and fish (8G/8H).**



Even lean, those six arm the community with science and root protection in tradition — the Palauan template.

## WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Palau's field is mostly favorable, with a strong conservation tradition, but development pressure and scale tilt it, so plan for it.

**When the harm isn't obvious.** Clearing land and cutting mangroves can seem a local matter until science shows the reef harm. Don't wait: get clear reef science to show the land-to-sea link, as Palauans did.

**When your power is close to home.** The great national acts came from national leadership; a community's power is strongest at the state and traditional level. Aim there, on the land and reefs closest to home, where your science and your tradition carry most weight.

**When development pressure is real.** Small, beautiful islands face real pressure to build. Lean on the science, the leaders closest to home, the "bul," and community protected areas, which have turned understanding into lasting protection.

**When you want protection to last.** A ban can be won, but protection lasts through tradition and structure. Use the "bul" and community protected areas, built through an alliance, to make it hold.

## WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Palau is a small democracy with a strong conservation ethic, so outright corruption is less the pattern than pressure from development interests — but connected interests can still push a harmful project, so stay alert.

**How to spot it.** A practice or project pushed despite clear science of reef and fish harm; a development favored over the community's food and water; benefits to a developer while the reefs and families bear the cost.

**Who's supposed to guard against it.** The **state and traditional leaders** (who can act on the science), the community's own **"bul"** tradition and **protected areas, reef scientists and conservation groups**, and Palau's **national conservation leadership and free press** — all real in a small, conservation-minded democracy.

**How to fight it safely (and it is safe here).** Document precisely and factually — the clear science, the harm to reefs and fish, who benefits — and use Palau's channels: the state and traditional leaders, the "bul," the community protected areas, the scientists, and the public. In a small democracy with a living conservation tradition, clear science and a case rooted in custom are powerful.

## INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The clear science gives a leader something to act on; the reach to the leaders closest to home wins the ban or the protection; the "bul" and community protected areas make it last; the alliance multiplies it; the community sustains it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

**Early on (weeks–months):** get the clear land-to-sea science; identify the state and traditional leaders; root the effort in the community's fish, forests, and water.



**In the thick of it (months):** take the science to the leaders; win the ban or protection; propose a "bul"; build the alliance.

**The long haul (months–years):** establish community protected areas and sustain them through tradition, so the protection holds — for a practice banned and land, watersheds, and reefs safeguarded.

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive practice in Palau can be done, and made to last — a community armed with clear reef science took it to its own state and traditional leaders and won a ban on mangrove clearing, and community after community drew on the tradition of "bul" to establish protected areas that safeguard forests, watersheds, and reefs. Hold both truths. Palau's distinctive power is real: arm a community with clear science that links a project to the harm it does the reefs and fish people depend on, take it to the state and traditional leaders closest to home, and turn it — through the traditional "bul" moratorium and community-run protected areas — into lasting protection. And the constraints are real: the great national acts, the marine and shark sanctuaries, came from national leadership, and a community's power is strongest close to home, at the state and traditional level; the science must be clear and credible to persuade; and development pressure on small, beautiful islands is real.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Get clear science linking the practice to the harm it does the reefs and fish — because that clear link, and nothing weaker, is what a leader can act on, as the sediment science won the mangrove ban. Take it to the leaders closest to home — the state government and traditional leaders — with the power to ban the practice or protect the area. Turn understanding into lasting protection through Palau's own tradition: the "bul" moratorium, and community-run protected areas built together through an alliance. Count a practice banned, land and mangroves protected, and watersheds and reefs safeguarded as wins. That is how Palauans did it — clear science, the leaders closest to home, and a living tradition, turned into protection that holds. So can you.